

Definition of Weaning

Weaning is the gradual replacement of breastfeeding with other foods.Weaning is the process by which a baby slowly gets used to eating family or adult foods and relies less and less on breast milk.

Time of weaning

It is a gradual process starting around the age of 6 months, because the mother's milk alone is not sufficient to sustain growth beyond 6 months.

Supplementary foods

During weaning, suitable foods rich in protein and other nutrients are given to the child. These foods are called supplementary foods. These are usually cow's milk, fruit juice, soft cooked rice, dhal, vegetables and egg yolk. As far as possible, locally available foods should be used in weaning the child. The weaning/ supplementary foods do not replace breastmilk, they complement it. As the baby gets older it needs more food to grow and stay healthy.

Characteristics of ideal weaning foods

- High in energy
- Easy to digest
- Low in bulk and viscosity (not too thick)
- Fresh and clean
- Inexpensive and easy to prepare
- Not too highly seasoned

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Techniques of weaning

- Wash hand thoroughly with soap before preparation of weaning foods.
- Introduce one food at a time
- Let the baby get used to one food for a few days before introducing another.
- Start by giving one or two teaspoons and gradually increase the quantity
- Give food in addition to regular breast feeds.
- Do not use a feeding bottle.
- Slowly increase the number of meals and the amount of food given.
- Feed babies using a clean cup and spoon.
- Do not add water to the weaning food.
- Encourage the child to hold the food
- Encourage eating on its own
- Avoid force feeding
- Avoid ready made processed foods

By the age of eight months, most babies need four 'meals' a day including a variety of foods, in addition to regular breastfeeding. At one year old a child should be able to be given all types of family foods, although the food may still need to be softened or mashed. Patience is needed when babies are first starting to eat family foods. There is no need to buy expensive commercially manufactured weaning foods.

Rules for safe preparation of weaning foods

- Wash hands before preparing food
- Prepare weaning foods immediately before they will be eaten
- Wash all utensils before preparing food, and scrub chopping boards and tables
- Cook or boil food well
- Mash foods up with a clean spoon.

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